THE SARKARI FOLLIES

Lavish buildings, empty museums, fire-prone hospitals reveal a governance model where political image-building trumps safety, basic service and accountability

By ROHIT PARIHAR



WHEN VISHVARAJ SINGH, BJP MLA AND SCION OF THE MAHARANA PRATAP DYNASTY, expressed shock last week at "plans to build luxurious structures along the proposed Maharana Pratap tourist circuit in Rajasthan instead of conserving, restoring and developing sites associated with the revered Mewar ruler", he blew the lid of the state's failure to preserve its monuments. Vishvaraj's concern follows multiple reports that the United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (Unesco), in its last two meetings, warned the state it could withdraw Jaipur's Pink City heritage tag over failures in conservation and protection in development plans, with havelis being demolished either to make way for modern complexes or to prevent their collapse. The government needs to submit a status report by December 1, 2026, to be reviewed at Unesco's 47th meeting.

Across the state, the pattern repeats itself—grand ideas, poor planning, inflated budgets, negligible benefit and lack of maintenance. The October 5-6 midnight fire in the intensive care unit at the Trauma Centre in Jaipur's Sawai Man Singh (SMS) Hospital underscored the risks posed by poor maintenance in government buildings and what officials privately call Rajasthan's "governance by optics"—a preference for concrete showpieces over practical public service. Eight patients had died in the incident, triggered by a short circuit. This was the 16th such case reported at the public hospital in the past 18 months.

As investigators probed why the fire safety systems at the hospital did not work, a senior official of the Jaipur Development Authority (JDA), under the urban development and housing (UDH) department, pointed to the upcoming Cardiology Centre, being built at a cost of Rs 93 crore within the same complex. "There is no space for fire engines to reach the building," he says. "It's built on Roman-style pillars for show, not safety." The structure has no basement parking, which will force ambulances and patient vehicles to crowd its entrance. Its flawed design means the cardiology department, meant to shift here, cannot move in.

The delay has already stretched to over 20 months. Sanctioned as an eight-storey block, construction stopped at four floors—the rooftop now holds the chillers, tanks and the solar